

Effigia

It looked like a dinosaur, ran like a dinosaur, and probably fed like a dinosaur, too—but *Effigia* was no dinosaur. This Triassic reptile belonged to the same part of the reptile family tree as crocodiles and alligators but evolved a body shape remarkably similar to that of the ostrich dinosaurs (ornithomimids), which were not to appear until 80 million years later.



Effigia

eff-IJ-ee-ah

- **When** 210 million years ago (Late Triassic)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands of western N. America
- **Length** 5–10 ft (1.5–3 m)
- **Diet** Unknown but possibly omnivorous

Effigia walked on its hind legs, holding up its long tail for balance, and had very tiny arms. It had large eyes and a small, birdlike skull. Reptiles like *Effigia* were common in the Late Triassic but seem to have been killed by a change in climate caused by volcanic eruptions.



▲ WHO NEEDS TEETH?

Effigia had a beak but no teeth, which makes its diet hard to guess. Perhaps it used its beak to crack pine seeds or eggs. It may also have preyed on small animals.

